

ZOHO SETU PROJECT

SETU PROJECT

Baseline kernel OS

Software Domain

Description

Create a minimal 64-bit microkernel with core components like USB drivers, memory management, and a graphical shell.

Project Type: Linux

Category: Software Based

Atharva Bodade

Class: Third Year

Branch: Information Technology

Shri Sant Gajanan Maharaj College of Engineering, Shegaon

GitHub: <https://github.com/UnsettledAverage73/zoho-os>

Reference: <https://kernel.org/>

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Chapter 1

Vision & Problem Statement

The goal of this project is to develop a minimal, educational Linux-type kernel from scratch. It serves as a baseline for understanding low-level systems programming, memory management, and driver development.

1.1 The Limitations of Today

Modern kernels like Linux are incredibly complex, making it difficult for students and researchers to grasp the core fundamentals of how an OS interacts with hardware. This project aims to strip away the complexity to provide a clear, functional baseline.

1.2 Project Philosophy

Baseline kernel OS is built to be a minimal yet extensible system. This requires:

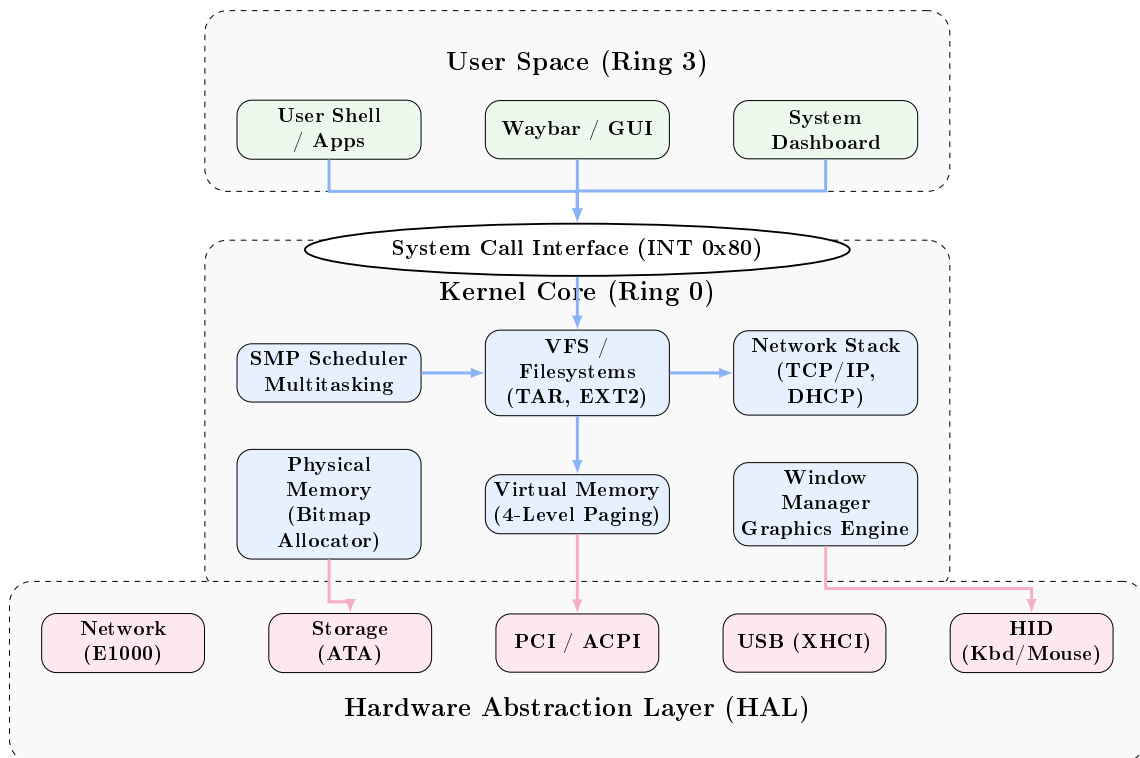
- **Educational Clarity:** Well-documented code that maps directly to architectural concepts.
- **Hardware Abstraction:** A clean interface between the kernel and the underlying x86_64 hardware.
- **Extensibility:** A modular design that allows for easy addition of new drivers and system calls.

Chapter 2

Architecture Overview

Baseline kernel OS implements a ****Modular Monolithic Architecture****. While all core services run within the same address space in Ring 0 for performance, the system is logically divided into strictly defined layers and modules to ensure maintainability and structural clarity.

2.1 System Architecture Diagram



2.2 Structural Integrity

The architecture is designed around three primary pillars:

- **Isolation:** User-space applications are strictly isolated from the kernel and each other via 4-level paging and hardware-enforced protection rings.

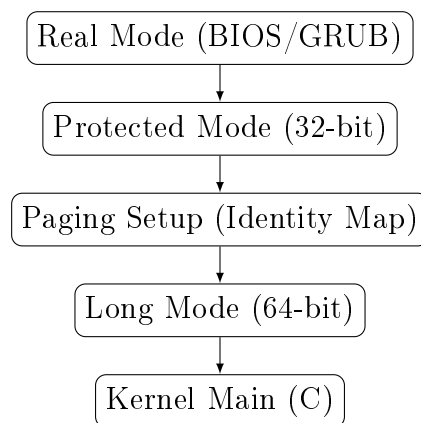
- **Abstraction:** The VFS and HAL provide a consistent interface for higher-level systems, allowing hardware-specific details to be swapped or updated without affecting the core logic.
- **Observability:** Integrated logging (`klog`), statistics (`kstats`), and tracing (`ktrace`) are built into the kernel core to facilitate real-time debugging and performance monitoring.

Chapter 3

Boot Process

The transition from a powered-off state to a running 64-bit environment involves a complex handoff between assembly and C.

3.1 Bootstrapping 64-bit Mode



3.2 Key Milestones

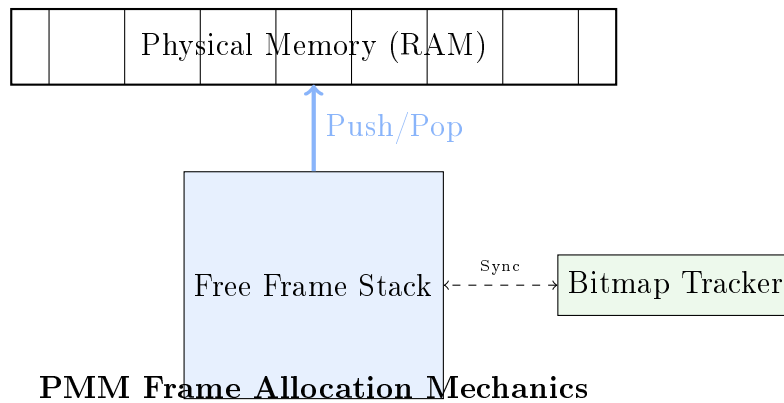
1. **Multiboot2 Header:** Allows GRUB to recognize the kernel.
2. **PAE Paging:** Necessary to address the 64-bit space.
3. **GDT Flush:** Loading the global descriptor table for code and data segments.

Chapter 4

Core Kernel Systems

4.1 Physical Memory Manager (PMM)

The PMM uses a stack-based frame allocator combined with a bitmap for high-performance memory tracking.



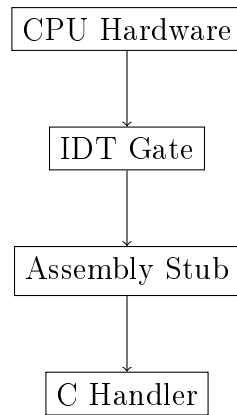
4.2 Virtual Memory Manager (VMM)

Baseline kernel OS implements a 4-level paging system.



4.3 Interrupt Handling & IDT

Baseline kernel OS manages hardware asynchronous events through a centralized Interrupt Descriptor Table (IDT).



4.4 SMP Scheduler & Task Management

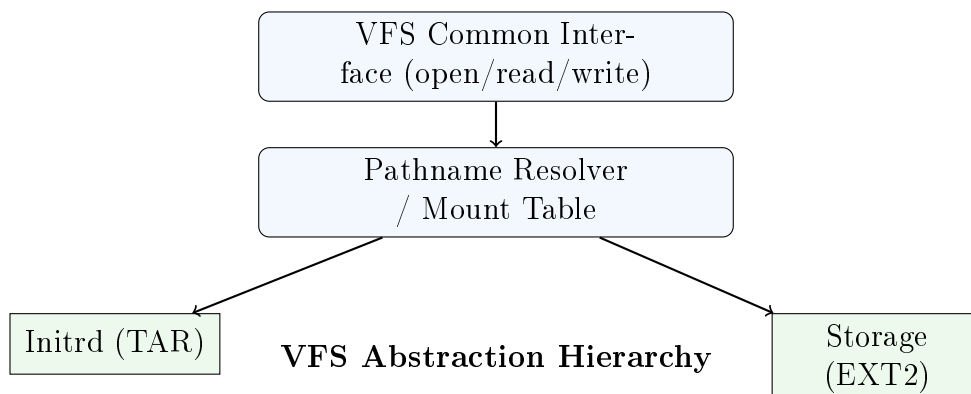
The scheduler implements a multicore round-robin algorithm with per-CPU runqueues and task stealing for dynamic load balancing.



SMP Multiprocessing & Load Balancing

4.5 Virtual File System (VFS)

The VFS layer abstracts underlying storage formats (TAR, EXT2) into a unified tree structure, allowing standardized access to diverse data sources.



- **Disk-backed TAR:** Used for the initial ramdisk and system applications.
- **Device Nodes:** Support for `/dev/tty` and `/dev/serial`.

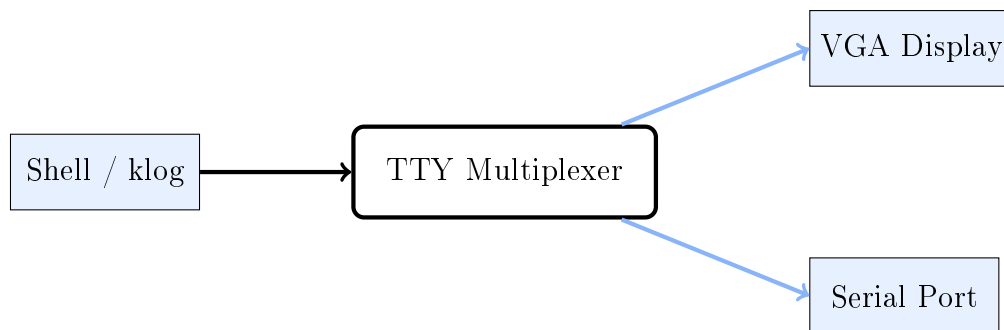
4.6 Observability (KStats & KTrace)

Baseline kernel OS includes built-in observability tools that track kernel performance from the earliest boot stages.

- **KStats:** Monitors physical memory usage, uptime, and active task counts.
- **KTrace:** Provides an event buffer for high-speed tracing of kernel execution paths, essential for debugging race conditions in SMP mode.

4.7 Terminal Abstraction (TTY)

The TTY layer provides a unified interface for text-based communication, multiplexing output between the local VGA framebuffer and the remote Serial (COM1) port.



TTY Output Multiplexing Flow

4.8 USB Support (XHCI)

Baseline kernel OS features an eXtensible Host Controller Interface (XHCI) driver foundation, enabling high-speed communication with USB 3.0 devices such as human interface devices (HID) and mass storage.

Chapter 5

Unique Features

5.1 Interactive Shell

Baseline kernel OS features a userland shell that supports basic file operations and system queries.

5.2 Video Demonstration

A full demonstration of the Baseline kernel OS boot process, kernel initialization, and interactive shell is available on YouTube.

[\[Watch the Baseline kernel OS Demo on YouTube\]](#)

5.3 Real-time System Monitor

The Dashboard task provides live CPU and Memory statistics. It runs as a separate kernel task, demonstrating the scheduler's ability to handle background observability.

5.4 GUI Performance Optimization

The window manager uses a "Dirty Rectangle" algorithm to minimize redraw overhead, combined with a dedicated kernel task to ensure smooth rendering even under heavy kernel load.

Chapter 6

Technical Challenges

6.1 Standardizing Framebuffer Pitch

Problem: Initial graphics implementation resulted in a black screen or skewed output on certain virtualized hardware. **Discovery:** I found that hardware often uses a ‘pitch’ (bytes per scanline) that is wider than the visible width. **Resolution:** Refactored all graphics primitives (`clear`, `blit`, `put_pixel`) to use `fb_pitch` for coordinate calculations instead of simple `width * 4`.

6.2 The Huge Page Corruption Bug

An `INT 6` fault occurred because the VMM treated 2MB Huge Pages as tables. **Resolution:** Refactored the identity map to use 4KB pages and updated VMM to handle flag propagation correctly. This ensures that 4KB mappings can coexist with the initial identity map without corrupting executable code.

6.3 Memory Overlap (OOM)

The heap and PMM were conflicting on the same physical range. **Resolution:** Explicitly reserved the 128MB heap range in the PMM bitmap.

Chapter 7

Future Roadmap

Baseline kernel OS is envisioned as a continuously evolving platform for systems research and education. The following roadmap outlines the strategic technical goals categorized by implementation horizon.

7.1 Short-Term: Stabilization & Core I/O

- **Complete XHCI Driver:** Move beyond the initialization stub to support USB HID (Keyboards/Mice) and Mass Storage protocols via the XHCI controller.
- **FAT32 Filesystem Support:** Implement a read/write driver for FAT32 to enable interoperability with standard bootable media and easier data exchange.
- **Userspace Standard Library (libc):** Develop a minimal C standard library to provide a stable API for userland application development, moving away from direct inline assembly syscalls.

7.2 Mid-Term: Performance & Compatibility

- **VirtIO Hardware Acceleration:** Implement VirtIO drivers for GPU and Network interfaces to achieve near-native performance in virtualized environments like QEMU and KVM.
- **Advanced Scheduling:** Transition the round-robin scheduler to a multi-level feedback queue (MLFQ) or a Completely Fair Scheduler (CFS) to better handle diverse workloads.
- **POSIX Signal Handling:** Implement a basic signal architecture to support standard process communication and exception handling in userland.

7.3 Long-Term: Self-Hosting & Distributed Systems

- **Self-Hosting Environment:** The ultimate milestone is to port a C compiler (like TCC or a minimal GCC) and an assembler to Baseline kernel OS, allowing the kernel to be recompiled from within itself.

- **Distributed Runtime for AI:** Research and implement a lightweight distributed memory architecture to support partitioned AI inference tasks across multiple network-linked OS instances.
- **Full Graphical Desktop Environment (DE):** Expand the current window manager into a full-featured DE with a taskbar, file manager, and system settings suite.

Chapter 8

System State

8.1 Terminal Output

The following section provides real-time logs and visual confirmation of the Baseline kernel OS build and execution process.

A terminal window with a dark background and a cityscape at night. The terminal displays the output of a Makefile build process for 'zoho-os'. The commands and their outputs are as follows:

```
zoho-os master } make run
mkdir -p isodir/boot/grub
cp kernel.bin isodir/boot/kernel.bin
mkdir -p ramdisk_root/bin
cp shell.elf ramdisk_root/bin/shell
echo "Hello from Zoho OS VFS!" > ramdisk_root/test.txt
tar -cvf ramdisk.tar -C ramdisk_root bin test.txt
bin/
bin/shell
test.txt
# Create raw HDD image (64MB)
dd if=/dev/zero of=hdd.img bs=1M count=64
64+0 records in
64+0 records out
67188864 bytes (67 MB, 64 MiB) copied, 0.182621 s, 367 MB/s
# Write TAR to LBA 2048 (1MB offset)
dd if=ramdisk.tar of=hdd.img seek=2048 conv=notrunc
20+0 records in
20+0 records out
10240 bytes (10 kB, 10 KiB) copied, 0.000171153 s, 59.8 MB/s
rm -rf ramdisk_root ramdisk.tar
echo 'set timeout=0' > isodir/boot/grub/grub.cfg
echo 'set default=0' >> isodir/boot/grub/grub.cfg
echo 'insmod all_video' >> isodir/boot/grub/grub.cfg
echo '' >> isodir/boot/grub/grub.cfg
echo 'menuentry "Zoho OS" {' >> isodir/boot/grub/grub.cfg
echo '  set gfxpayload=keep' >> isodir/boot/grub/grub.cfg
echo '  multiboot2 /boot/kernel.bin' >> isodir/boot/grub/grub.cfg
echo '  boot' >> isodir/boot/grub/grub.cfg
echo '}' >> isodir/boot/grub/grub.cfg
grub-mkrescue -o zoho_os.iso isodir
```

Figure 8.1: Build process and ISO generation via Makefile.

```

qemu-system-x86_64 -cdrom zoho_os.iso -drive file=hdd.img,format=raw -serial stdio -smp 4 -m 512M -device qemu-xhci -device usb-tablet
[INFO ] TTY: Initializing TTY subsystem...
[INFO ] TTY: TTY subsystem initialized.
[INFO ] KERNEL: Zoho OS Booting...
PMM Initialized. Total free frames: Done.
[INFO ] KMMALLOC: Kernel heap initialized at 16MB (Size: 16MB)
[INFO ] KSTATS: Initializing kernel statistics...
[INFO ] KSTATS: Kernel statistics initialized.
[INFO ] KTRACE: Initializing kernel tracing...
[INFO ] KTRACE: Kernel tracing initialized.
[INFO ] ACPI: Initializing ACPI...
[INFO ] ACPI: Found Root
[INFO ] ACPI: Enumerated CPUs
[INFO ] ACPI: Step 1: MSR
[INFO ] ACPI: Step 2: Mapping
[INFO ] ACPI: Step 3: SVR
[INFO ] ACPI: DONE
[INFO ] PIT: Timer initialized at 100Hz
[INFO ] TASK: Task system initialized for CPU
[INFO ] SYSCALL: Syscall system initialized
[INFO ] PCI: Enumerating PCI devices...
[INFO ] PCI: Found device: Vendor=0x8086, Device=0x1237, Class=0x0, Subclass=0x0
[INFO ] PCI: Found device: Vendor=0x8086, Device=0x7080, Class=0x0, Subclass=0x1
[INFO ] PCI: Found function: Vendor=0x8086, Device=0x7010, Class=0x1, Subclass=0x1
[INFO ] PCI: Found function: Vendor=0x8086, Device=0x7113, Class=0x6, Subclass=0x80
[INFO ] PCI: Found device: Vendor=0x1234, Device=0x1111, Class=0x3, Subclass=0x0
[INFO ] PCI: Found device: Vendor=0x8086, Device=0x100e, Class=0x2, Subclass=0x0
[INFO ] E1000: Initializing Intel E1000 NIC...
[INFO ] E1000: BAR0 Physical Address: 0xfebc0000
[INFO ] E1000: MAC Address: 52:54:00:12:34:56
[INFO ] E1000: E1000 Initialized successfully.
[INFO ] PCI: Found device: Vendor=0x1b36, Device=0x0, Class=0xc, Subclass=0x3
[INFO ] XHCI: Initializing XHCI (USB 3.0) controller...

```

Figure 8.2: Early kernel initialization and subsystem startup logs.

8.2 Text-based Boot Logs

```

[INFO ] TTY: Initializing TTY subsystem...
[INFO ] TTY: TTY subsystem initialized.
[INFO ] KERNEL: Baseline kernel OS Booting...
PMM Initialized. Total free frames: Done.
[INFO ] KMMALLOC: Kernel heap initialized at 16MB (Size: 16MB)
[INFO ] KSTATS: Initializing kernel statistics...
[INFO ] KSTATS: Kernel statistics initialized.
[INFO ] KTRACE: Initializing kernel tracing...
[INFO ] KTRACE: Kernel tracing initialized.
[INFO ] ACPI: Initializing ACPI...
[INFO ] PCI: Enumerating PCI devices...
[INFO ] XHCI: Initializing XHCI (USB 3.0) controller...
[INFO ] XHCI: XHCI subsystem initialized (stub).
[INFO ] NET: Network stack initialized with IP 10.0.2.15

Baseline kernel OS Interactive Shell
zoho> ls
bin/
bin/shell
test.txt

```



```
[INFO ] CPU: CPU initialized
[INFO ] APIC: Step 1: MSR
[INFO ] APIC: Step 2: Mapping
[INFO ] APIC: Step 3: SVR
[INFO ] APIC: DONE
[INFO ] TASK: Task system initialized for CPU
[INFO ] SMP: Multi-core bring-up complete.
[INFO ] ATA: Initializing ATA driver (Polling mode)...
[INFO ] ATA: Primary Master detected.
[INFO ] EXT2: Initializing Ext2 driver...
[WARN ] EXT2: Not present, falling back to TAR
[INFO ] VFS: Virtual File System initialized (Block-backed).
[INFO ] TAR: Disk-backed TAR initialized.
[INFO ] GRAPHICS: Initializing Framebuffer...
[INFO ] GRAPHICS: Framebuffer initialized at fd000000
[INFO ] MOUSE: Initializing PS/2 Mouse...
[INFO ] MOUSE: Mouse initialized.
[INFO ] NET: Network stack initialized with IP 10.0.2.15

Zoho OS Interactive Shell
zoho> [INFO ] DHCP: Sending DISCOVER...
[INFO ] NET: TX UDP: 10.0.2.15:68 -> 255.255.255.255:67, Len=264
[INFO ] NET: TX Eth: Dst=ff:ff:ff:ff:ff:ff, Type=0x800, Len=272
[INFO ] KERNEL: System stabilized on LAPIC Timer. Starting scheduler...
ls
bin/
bin/shell
test.txt
zoho> ls
bin/
bin/shell
test.txt
zoho> .
zoho-os master }
```

Figure 8.3: Interactive shell session and final system stabilization.

Chapter 9

Research & References

The development of Baseline kernel OS was informed by extensive research into x86_64 architecture, low-level systems programming, and modern kernel design paradigms. The following resources served as primary technical references.

1. **OSDev Wiki Contributors.** (2026). *OSDev Wiki: The primary resource for OS development.* Available at: <https://wiki.osdev.org/>
2. **Intel Corporation.** (2026). *Intel 64 and IA-32 Architectures Software Developer's Manual, Volume 3: System Programming Guide.* Available at: [Intel SDM](#)
3. **GNU Project.** (2026). *Multiboot2 Specification, version 2.0.* Available at: [GNU.org](#)
4. **UEFI Forum.** (2026). *Advanced Configuration and Power Interface (ACPI) Specification, Revision 6.4.* Available at: [UEFI.org](#)
5. **Intel Corporation.** (2026). *eXtensible Host Controller Interface (xHCI) for Universal Serial Bus, Revision 1.2.* Available at: [Intel xHCI Spec](#)
6. **PCI-SIG.** (2026). *PCI Local Bus Specification, Revision 3.0.* Available at: [PCI-SIG.com](#)
7. **Torvalds, L., et al.** (2026). *Linux Kernel Source Tree.* Available at: [Linux Github](#)

Contact & Links

Atharva Bodade

atharvabodade@gmail.com

ssgm_308217@ssgmce.ac.in

[GitHub Profile](#)

[LinkedIn Profile](#)

[Project Reference](#)